BJP, as Narendra Modi was at the beginning of his career. In 2009, when thirty-five pracharaks were said to be working in the BJP, RSS Chief Mohan Bhagwat was questioned about their influence. He responded by saying that it 'is not compulsory that they report to us. We only want them to stick to their principles. We don't interfere in their work.'[58]

The crucial question is: who is the boss in this relationship? Bhagwat has insisted in the past that the 'RSS never intervenes, only gives advice when asked'. Yet, it is also true that, in 2013, when the ascendance of Narendra Modi as the BJP's prime ministerial candidate was not yet clear and there was a power tussle within the party—with several Delhi leaders' names doing the rounds—it was Bhagwat who publicly said that 'the new leadership will be someone from outside Delhi other than these four [Sushma Swaraj, Arun Jaitley, Ananth Kumar and Venkaiah Naidu]. This is what I have been told. That is what has been agreed on and I believe the process has begun.'[59]

The BJP–RSS relationship is essentially a symbiotic one. On 15–16 November 1987, then RSS chief Balasaheb Deoras reportedly said that the RSS planned to enter politics. It was the only time that the Sangh came close to formally entering the domain of electoral politics. Three years later, on 17 March 1990, Advani announced in a famous speech at an RSS meeting in Coimbatore: 'We have to intensify our efforts to project the viewpoint of the RSS … There has been a conscious effort on the part of Swayamsevaks who are working in the BJP to make each one understand the ideological base to which we belong and our connections with sister organisations like the VHP, the ABVP, the BMS, the Sena Bharati and the Kalyan Ashram which are all based on the inspiration from the RSS.'[60]

Fundamentally, the BJP and the RSS are conjoined. The fact that so much of the party's top leadership is populated by the RSS means that the two organisations may be separate but come from a common fountainhead of ideas. In 2000, when the journalist Rajesh Joshi asked RSS Joint General Secretary Madan Das Devi if 95 per cent of the BJP was RSS, he famously retorted, 'If you say 95% I don't agree. It's a different thing to say that the BJP draws most of its